



INDIE HACKING, BY THE NUMBERS

The Indie Hacker Reality Check

What 1,000 real, revenue-verified startups say about where to build next

1,000

startups analyzed

• **\$13.5M**

combined MRR

• **40+**

countries

Prepared for: a founder deciding what to build

Source: TrustMRR dataset · frozen 30 Jul 2026

It's a power law, not a level field

\$282

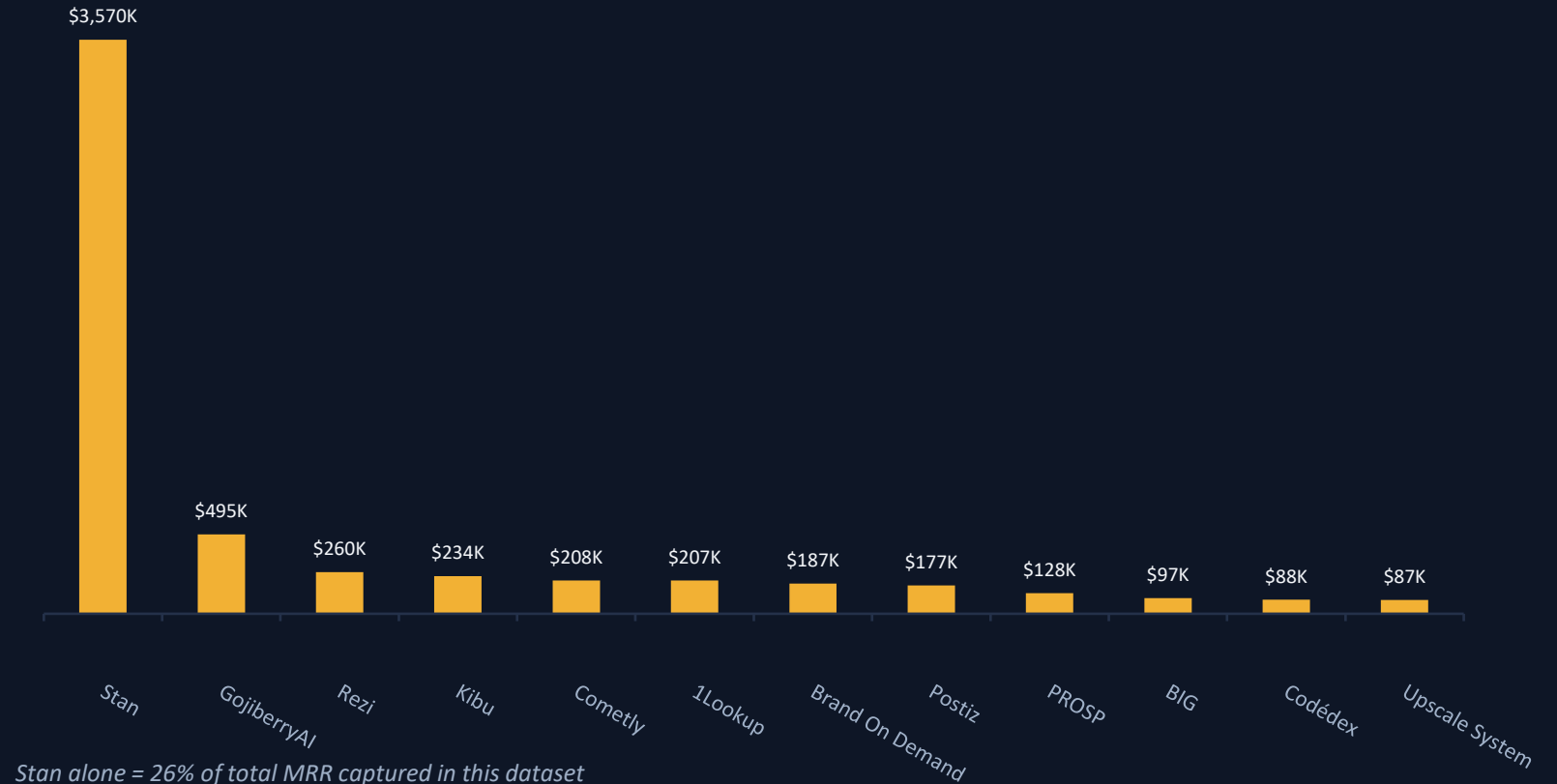
Median monthly recurring revenue across all 1,000 startups

48%

of all MRR in the dataset is earned by just the top 10 startups

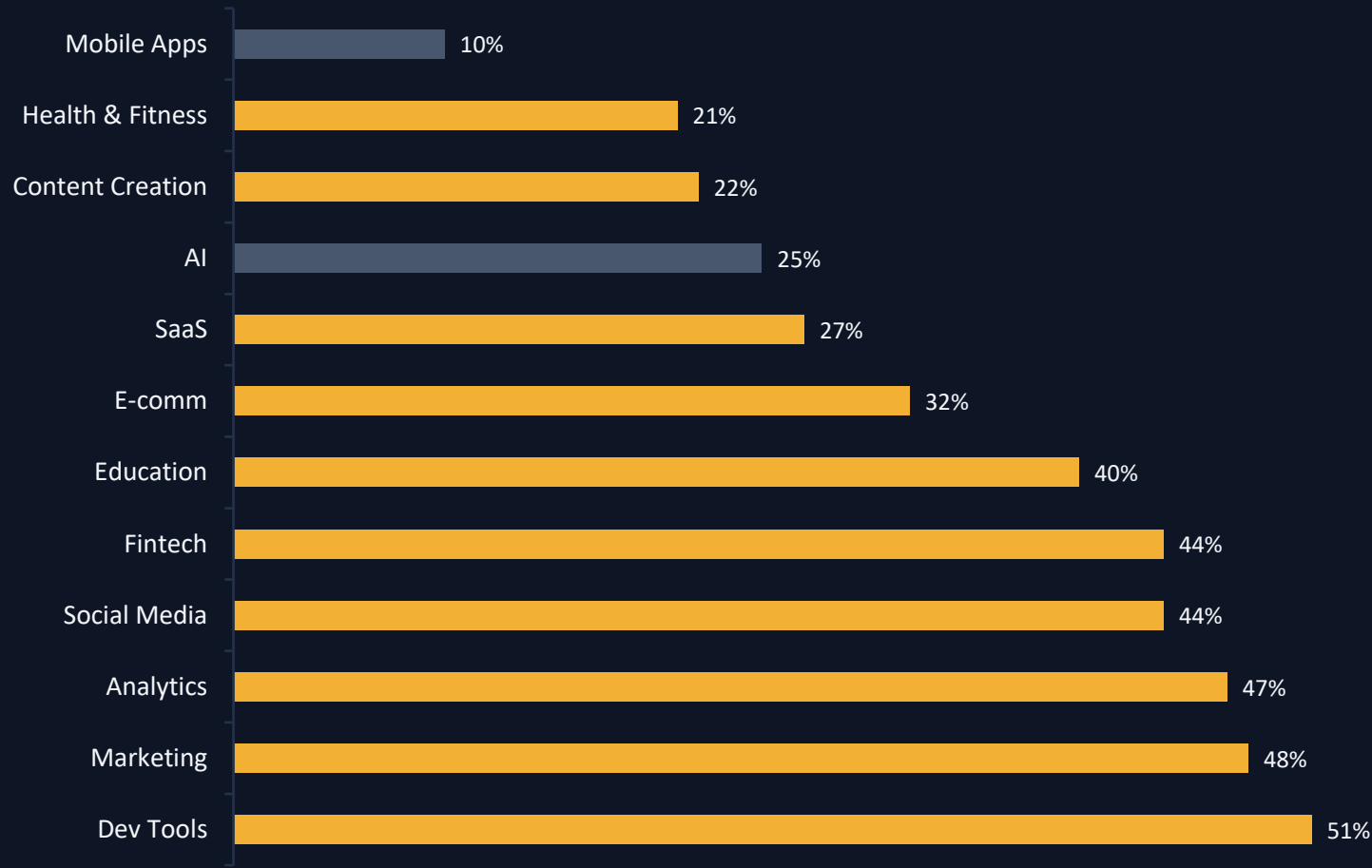
Most swings miss. Building for a durable niche beats chasing a jackpot.

Top 12 startups by MRR — one company dwarfs the rest





The AI label is crowded — not where growth is



Share of startups in category with positive MoM MRR growth

197

startups tag themselves “AI” — 27% of the dataset, the single largest category

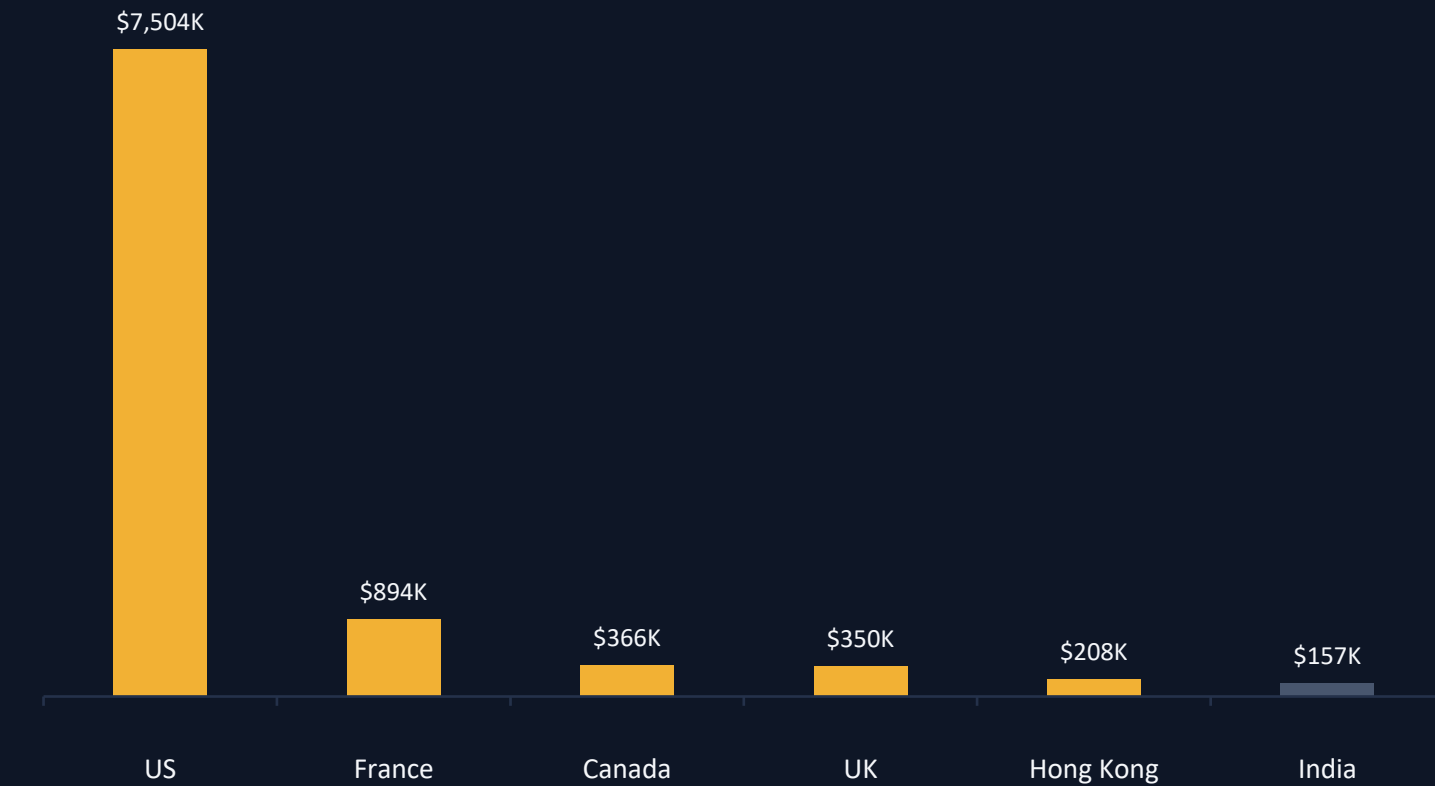
1 in 4

of them are actually growing month over month — the weakest hit-rate of any major category



Building ≠ earning

Total MRR by founder country



Startup count — US 258 · France 79 · Canada 29 · UK 50 · Hong Kong 19 · India 59

41%

of India-based startups earn \$0/month in MRR right now

Yet India is the 3rd-largest founder base by count (59 startups) — activity that hasn't converted into paying customers.

Where you build shapes whether the market will pay.



Charge businesses, not consumers

B2B

\$1,036

median monthly recurring revenue
across 255 B2B startups



B2C

\$181

median monthly recurring revenue
across 401 B2C startups



B2B products earn 5.7× more per company than B2C — even though B2C has more startups chasing it.



The playbook for your next build

01

Plan for the median, not the miracle

Half of all indie startups make under \$282/mo. Build something that can sustain you at modest scale — don't plan your runway around a Stan-sized outlier.

02

Skip the AI-label rush

AI is the most crowded category and has the weakest growth rate. Dev Tools, Marketing, Analytics, and Fintech show more startups actually growing, with less noise.

03

Pick your market on purpose

The US and France convert founder activity into revenue. If you're building elsewhere, validate willingness to pay before you validate the idea.

04

Sell to businesses first

B2B commands roughly 5.7× the revenue per customer of B2C. A smaller, well-paying business audience beats a large free one.